WINTER IN OUR BONES
WATER TO OUR SOULS



MICHIGAN

THE MUSICAL

When a data center threatens their grandparents' lake house, Lulu and Petoskey – a fierce Dearborn city girl and hopeful Yooper farm boy – must conquer years of grief to save their home... and the world.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

THE VAN OTTERLOO FAMILY

LULU VAN OTTERLOO ABUGHOSH describes herself as a Middle Eastern girl in the middle of the Midwestern world. A 13-year-old born and raised in Dearborn, she wears solid colors, hoping to collect better rocks than Cousin Petoskey every year. She is writing *Dearborn*, a musical about deer navigating the talking Great Lakes. She plays banjo and is Iggy Pop's biggest fan. Her name is Arabic meaning "pearl."

PETOSKEY VAN OTTERLOO describes himself as a rocky Yooper farm boy skipping the Great Lakes water. A 13-year-old from Skandia, he wears patterns and trapper hats. He connects with his ancestors through his heart-shaped Petoskey heirloom with an elk symbol. He loves to go fishing; he just needs a parent to do it with.

LIZZIE GLYNN VAN OTTERLOO is Petoskey's mother and narrator in Skandia. After a tragedy in 2008, she stops crossing the Mackinac Bridge to attend Harbor Days and family gatherings. Liz is a proud Yooper and shipbuilder. Michigan State.

PETEY VAN OTTERLOO is Petoskey's father, Liz's husband, and Willy and Milly's only son of four. During the recession, his and Liz's blue-collar shipyard job replaces them with migrants. His spirit lives within Petoskey. Michigan State.

SHELBY VAN OTTERLOO ABUGHOSH is Petoskey's aunt, Petey's little sister, and Lulu's mother in Dearborn. She is a Ford Motor worker. As the family member who broke the mold by being a Midwesterner who fell in love with a Middle Easterner, she and Petey has a tumultuous relationship. Kettering University.

PERRY VAN OTTERLOO is Petoskey's aunt and Petey's campy sister in Lansing. Her heart is in science, yet she has a conspiracy theory mindset and plotted to kidnap the governor. Michigan Technological University and Eastern Michigan dropout.

CHERRY VAN OTTERLOO JACOBOWITZ is Petoskey's aunt and Petey's oldest sister in Kalamazoo. She arranges the theme and costumes for the annual Harbor Days parade. She is married to a Grand Rapids Griffins hockey manager. Hope College.

JACOB VAN OTTERLOO JACOBOWITZ is Cherry's son who is a Broadway actor in New York. He is the 2022 Grand Marshal for the Harbor Days Grande Parade where he is dressed as Wednesday from *The Addams Family*. He recently performed on the national tour of this show. Western Michigan University.

LIBERTY AND **BAILEY VAN OTTERLOO** are twin siblings and Petoskey, Lulu, and Jacob's little cousins removed from reality. They are from Hell… Michigan.

Michigan

MILLY VAN OTTERLOO is Petoskey's bold grandmother and inventor. She invented the auto-toilet. With Willy, she owns a Lake House by Elk Lake in Elk Rapids. She and Willy stumble into the audience every so often. Central Michigan.

WILLY VAN OTTERLOO is Petoskey's chill grandfather and gardener. With Milly, he owns a Lake House by Elk Lake in Elk Rapids. He and Milly stumble into the audience every so often. Northern Michigan University.

MICHIGANDERS

JASPER VINH CHIN is Petey's resourceful childhood friend and Petoskey's godfather/godmother who runs the BANH MIchigan Vietnamese restaurant and a golf course. As a teen, they once looked down on the migrant community when a Lebanese family bought out his family's original struggling restaurant. Ferris State.

AMANDA WAYLAND is the CEO of Turkey Ventures from Muskegon with the goal of turning every lake city into a data center. Following her brother Conor's death, she loses her creative spirit and takes over her brother's business to create Afterlife.AI to bring late loved ones back as avatars. She was an art school rival of Cherry, before getting expelled. Hope College dropout. University of Michigan.

DETECTIVE is an investigator along the Mackinac Bridge.

THE GHOST OF HENRY FORD returns from Hell.

MICHILIMACKINAC, the Mackinac spirit resembling the Great Turtle.

THE KEEPERS OF FAITH, FIRE, TRADE are the original people of the land

MICHIGANDERS, **RESIDENTS, LAWMAKERS**, **OLIGARCHS**, **RADIO**, anyone who speaks in "ope."

PROLOGUE

EXT. ELK LAKE HOUSE IN ELK RAPIDS - AUGUST 2008 - DAY

1. "OVERTURE/THE MITTEN SONG"

Next to the shores of Elk Lake, the VAN OTTERLOOS camp in tents. The old Lake House is behind them.

PETEY (30s, adorable man) leaves his tent. He wears mittens. With a yawn, he bangs pots and pans.

PETEY
WAKEY WAKEY, SUN.
LET'S WEAR OUR MITTENS
AND COOK 'EM EGGS WITH LOTSA BACON
FOR OUR GODSEND, MICHIGAN!
SLEPT WELL, HUN...?

LIZZIE (30s, pregnant narrator) crawls out of Petey's tent, ready to smack her noisy hubby.

End of "OVERTURE/THE MITTEN SONG"

2. "LIFE IS COMPLETE"

LIZZIE
THAT'S THE LOVE OF MY LIFE.
BUT EVERY MORNING, HE'S PUBLIC ENEMY NUMBER ONE.

The three Van Otterloo sisters - CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY (pregnant) - crawl out of their tents.

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
TO HIS WIFE, LIZZIE...

PETEY
AND ONE TWO AND THREE LOONEY SISTERS!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
THE VAN OTTERLOO SISTERS!

CHERRY
CHERRY!

PERRY
PERRY!

SHELBY
SHELBY!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
WET WILLY!

PETEY
Eeeekkkkk!!!

The Sisters give Bro a wet willy as GRANNY MILLY and GRAMPY WILLY roam in the Audience.

WILLY
DID SOMEONE SAY WET WILLY?!

MILLY
OR WET MILLY?

PETEY, CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
EW... MOM AND DAD, THAT'S GROSS!

WILLY
WHAT?!

MILLY
HUH?!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
GO PUT ON YOUR HEARING AIDS.

The Couple tune their hearing aids.

WILLY & MILLY
GREAT!

MILLY
GRAMPY WILLY.
WE'VE GOT COMPANY.

WILLY
GRANNY MILLY.
REAL GOOD COMPANY.

WILLY & MILLY
AIN'T LIFE SOMETHIN'?

MILLY
YOU HAVE COME A LONG WAY, FRIENDS.

WILLY
TO THE GREATEST BAY IN ALL THE GREAT LAKES!

MILLY
BAKED YOUR KIDS FRESH COOKIES,
MAKE YOURSELF COMFY.

Milly hands out cookies. Willy removes his shoes. The pit pukes.

MILLY (CONT'D)
Ugh! Ya scaring our guests with your clam feet!

WILLY
I've been working out. My legs are made of mussels. M-U-S-S-E-L-S? Get it?

MILLY
Your dad jokes are getting old, Grampy Willy.

WILLY
Not as old as you, Granny Milly...

MILLY
Shush! The guests are gonna think we're Midwest silly instead of normal silly.

PETEY
Ma! Pa! Who are you talking to???!

LIZZIE
You should put ya parents in a retirement h-

WILLY & MILLY
Our hearing aids heard that! Maestro?!
LIFE IS COMPLETE WITH OUR CRAZY FAMILY!

The Van Otterloos wear Red Wings.

Liz points to Elk Rapids using her hand as Michigan.

LIZZIE
Welcome to Harbor Days with the Van Otterloo family! What's Harbor Days you ask? For four days in August, it's an Elk Rapids tradition. That's all I know. I've gone to these since Petey and I were high school sweethearts. We also go while tailgating Michigan State...

PETEY
Go Green!

AUDIENCE
Go White!

LIZZIE
...and I still have no clue what Harbor Days is even about.

CHERRY
It's about the parade, sweetheart.

PERRY
Nah, it's about the carnival, yo!

SHELBY
Actually, it's about the fireworks, deary!

WILLY & MILLY
It's about the Lake House.

WILLY
My genius, Milly. She invented the auto-toilet then flushed her money to buy this Lake House.

MILLY
That ain't how you use the expression, sweetie. Well, my creative Willy tends to our garden.

WILLY
Did you put a turtle in the koi pond? That turtle ate all of our koi fish!

CHERRY
It's my son, Jacob. Little teenage rascal...

LIZZIE
She’s Petey's oldest sister, Cherry Van Otterloo Jacobowitz. Her family’s in Kalamazoo. She's a costume designer and her hubby played hockey with the Grand Rapids Griffins.

Cherry shows Kalamazoo on her hand.

CHERRY
The only pucks I give is winning the Most Creative Award at the annual Grande Parade.

LIZZIE
Ever since she was little, Cherry would make the family wear elaborate costumes.

CHERRY
2008 is Red Wings’s year.

PETEY
They just beat Pittsburgh Penguins...

SHELBY
...to win the Stanley Cup. Woop!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
Let’s win that 2008 Most Creative Award!
NO ONE BEATS THE VAN OTTERLOOS!

LIZZIE
No one beats us like this 2008 recession. Michigan's been hit hard. Budget’s tight. The shipyard in Marquette fired me and Petey. We can only hope that we don't lose our house.

Lizzie shows Marquette on her hand.

PERRY
If this scavenger has kept her den, any other coyote can.

LIZZIE
This is Perry. She and Petey, middle children.

PERRY
I’m in the middle of greatness!

LIZZIE
Single. College dropout. Can never hold a job.

PERRY
I’ve been at Lansing Impression Science Center!

Perry shows Lansing on her hand.

LIZZIE
Welp, she's the smartest person I know.

SHELBY
What does that make me?

LIZZIE
Pregnancy sistahs!

SHELBY
Whoo yeah!

LIZZIE
Shelby Van Otterloo Abughosh, Petey's youngest sister. How's Ford in Dearborn holding up?

Shelby shows Dearborn on her hand.

SHELBY
Assembly line’s fine, thanks to my husband. He got his Kurdish friends jobs. Minimum wage, but what more could one ask for in recession times?

PETEY
Midwest Middle Easterners stealing our jobs-

LIZZIE
Petey... Her husband never attends Harbor Days thanks to that attitude of yours.

PETEY
He married Shelby for citizenship. He’d dump her when he gets the chance.

SHELBY
Immigrants built the coasts, harbors, country.

The Michigan communities from the Amish to Jewish, Christians to Muslims, auto workers to farmers, college sport fans to trade school artisans make themselves known.

MICHIGANDERS
OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE! OPE!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
LIFE AIN'T COMPLETE...

LIZZIE
WITHOUT...

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
COMMUNITY!

MICHIGANDERS
COMMUNITY!

MICHIGANDERS (CONT'D)
THE WORLD SITS ON OUR FURNITURE!
PEOPLE CAN GET ANYWHERE IN OUR CARS!
OUR CHERRY FARMS ARE THE CHERRY ON TOP!

JASPER VINH CHIN (30s, Vietnamese) opens the BANH MI restaurant.

JASPER
AND LET'S NOT FORGET!

PETEY
ELK RAPIDS HAS THE BEST VIETNAMESE RESTAURANT!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
MICHIGAN HAS THE BEST VIETNAMESE COMMUNITY!

JASPER
IN THE WHOLE WORLD!

MICHIGANDERS
LIFE AIN'T COMPLETE WITHOUT BANH MI!

JASPER
BANH MIIIIIIIIIIICHIGAN!

MICHIGANDERS
SAY THAT AGAIN!

JASPER
BANH MICHIGAN!
BANH MIchigan, a Vietnamese family-owned restaurant in Elk Rapids, Michigan. Home to Banh Mi Thit, Banh Mi Heo, Banh Mi Xiu Mai, Banh Mi Ga Nuong, and home to our latest Detroit-style Banh Mi-

PETEY
Banh Mi is also what I called home. Jasper!

JASPER
Petey! Happy Harbor Days to you, and Lizzie, and your soon-to-be baby!

LIZZIE
Got any Banh Mi baby formula?

JASPER
Way ahead of ya!

PETEY
Come on by the Lake House for o' time sake.

JASPER
Kosher Banh Mi for Cherry's son Jacob and sourdough for Willy and Milly?

PETEY
Always able to make Banh Mi for everyone.

JASPER
Cause Banh Mi is you and me!

VAN OTTERLOOS
LIFE AIN'T COMPLETE WITHOUT...

PERRY
RIGHT WING RADIO!

PETEY
Ah, I see...

CHERRY
Outta all of us...

SHELBY
You're coocoo.

PETEY, CHERRY, SHELBY
What's wrong with you?

PERRY
I'll tell you what's wrong: anything not right.

AMANDA WAYLAND (30s, all business) gets on stage for an interview.

RADIO (O.S.)
We have a special guest on The Patriot. Amanda Wayland, CEO of the creative startup, Turkey Ventures. First, we express our condolences for your loss.

CHERRY
My art nemesis...

AMANDA
Life's been incomplete without my cofounder. But we believe what would complete the lives of many going through grief... and that is AI.

RADIO
(Laughing)
It’s 2008. Not 2080. AI is going nowhere.

VAN OTTERLOOS W/O PERRY
What’s so funny? AI...?

PERRY
Artificial intelligence.

CHERRY
Too bad she didn’t have art intelligence. She wouldn’t been expelled from our art school.

PERRY
Cut her some slack. She lost her cofounder.

CHERRY
I’d cut her if she hadn’t stabbed me in the back. Boo hoo, she’s going through loss. She didn’t need to lose her artistic integrity too.

AMANDA & VAN OTTERLOOS
LIFE AIN’T COMPLETE WITH ENEMIES AND RIVALRIES.

Willy drives in the Ford Model T.

WILLY
AND OUR FORD MODEL T!

MICHIGANDERS
THE FORD MODEL T!

CHERRY, PERRY, SHELBY
DADDY GOT SOME WHEELIES.

MICHIGANDERS (CONT’D)
WILLY GOT SOME WHEELIES.

WILLY & MILLY
THIS BABY’S JUST A CENTURY YOUNG.

Liz, Petey, Shelby, and Jasper hang out by Elk Lake.

LIZZIE
Watcha naming your daughter?

SHELBY
Lulu! It means “pearl.” And your ibnuki (إِبْنُكِ)?

Petey looks disgusted.

LIZZIE
Lulu is jameela (جميلة). No clue.

JASPER
I bet Petey’s got an ace up his sleeves.

PETEY
More like *stone*.

Petey and Jasper hop into Elk Lake, splashing each other.

PETEY (CONT'D)
We won't name our son. A rock in Elk Lake will!

Petey dives into Elk Lake.

JASPER
Jasper! *Jasper*! *Jasper*!

LIZZIE
This gotta be a joke...

Petey resurfaces with a heart-shaped, Elk-marked Petoskey stone.

MICHIGANDERS
(Gospel)
PETOSKEY...
PETOSKEY...
THE JEWEL OF MICHIGAN...

LIZZIE
WE AIN'T NAMING OUR SON THAT.

JASPER
How about naming your second kid, Jasper?!

PETEY
WE DON'T HAVE TO NAME HIM PET-

Liz kisses Petey. They join the rest of the family, marching in the Harbor Days Grande Parade.

LIZZIE
ISN'T LIFE BEAUTIFUL?

PETEY (CONT'D)
ISN'T LIFE WORTH LIVING?

VAN OTTERLOOS
LIFE IS COMPLETE WITH OUR

MICHIGANDERS
LIFE IS COMPLETE WITH THIS

LIZZIE
CRAZY

PETEY
SASSY

CHERRY
WORKY

PERRY
NERDY

SHELBY
DERPY

WILLY
WILLY

MILLY
LOVELY

JASPER & MICHIGANDERS
WELCOMING...

VAN OTTERLOOS
FAMILY!

The Michiganders give Milly the Most Creative Award plaque.

End of “LIFE IS COMPLETE”

Liz’s phone rings. She answers.

LIZZIE
No! Please! Life is incomplete without it!

Liz slams her flip phone. She nod at Petey. He holds her close.

PETEY
Our house? No no no. Rest assured, all that matters is that we have our lives ahead.

Liz lets go. She exits with everyone clearing the parade.

PETEY (CONT’D)
We ain’t losing our house... I’ve got my life insurance... Let’s trade.

Elk Lake becomes Mackinac Strait.

EXT. MACKINAC BRIDGE - EVENING

3. “BODY OF WATER”

In the foggy storm, Petey ponders.

PETEY
EVERY LIVING THING IS MADE OF WATER.
EVERY MACHINERY NEEDS THE FLOW OF WATER.
ALL THE WEATHER TAKE THE HEATED WATER.
ALL THE SEASONS BRING THE COOLING WATER.

I BRING NOTHING TO THE WORLD UNLIKE WATER.
I’VE BROUGHT NOTHING TO THE WORLD BUT TEARS!

The MACKINAC GHOSTS manifest, resembling those who died there.

MACKINAC GHOSTS
DRINK IT. DRINK THE WATER.
THINK STRAIGHT. THINK STRAIGHTFORWARD.

PETEY
I BRING NOTHING TO THE WORLD.

MACKINAC GHOSTS
CHERISH. CHERISH THIS ONE LIFE.

PETEY
JUST TEARS!
HELP!

The Ghosts steal Petey's stone.

MACKINAC GHOSTS
HELP? HELL, HELP YOURSELF!

A Motherly Ghost returns with a Petoskey necklace. Petey wears it.

PETEY
I CHOOSE LIFE!

MACKINAC GHOSTS (CONT'D)
TAKE IT IN.

PETEY (CONT'D)
DRINK THE GREAT LAKES WATER.
THINK PAIN. PAIN YOU'LL CAUSE.
HAPPY WIFE. BABY IN SIGHT. DYING AIN'T RIGHT.

MACKINAC GHOSTS
DRINK IT. DRINK THE WATER.
THINK STRAIGHT. THINK STRAIGHTFORWARD.
CHERISH. CHERISH LIGHT.

PETEY
HELP MYSELF TO THIS GREAT WATER!

Petey drives the car away.

Emergency vehicles lights beat the morning Sun. The orchestra wails.

Liz rushes in with the DETECTIVE. She stops in her tracks, kneeling.

LIZZIE
LIFE IS A COMPLETE... DISASTER...
LIFE IS INCOMPLETE WITHOUT PETE-

DETECTIVE
WE ARE SORRY TO REPORT THE CAR SUBMERGED UNDER MACKINAC BRIDGE IS IDENTIFIED AS YOURS...

LIZZIE
AND...?

DETECTIVE
NO BODIES.
NOBODY.

The Detective hands the Petoskey necklace to Liz, then leaves.

LIZZIE
NOBODY LOVES ME LIKE THIS BODY OF WATER...

The Ghost of Petey manifests.

MACKINAC GHOSTS (V.O.)
NOBODY...

LIZZIE
WITH MY LAST TEAR, I'M OUT OF WATER IN MY HEART.

PETEY
YOU ARE MY SOUL.

MACKINAC GHOSTS (V.O.)
NOBODY...

Petey closes Liz's hand, sealing the Petoskey. Then, he vanishes.

End of "BODY OF WATER"

LIZZIE
Bridges are supposed to unite lands, not divide souls. Our house has been spared thanks to my hubby's life insurance. But I didn't mind losing *what* is called home when it meant losing *who* I called home. I just wanna sink like a rock-

Shelby, bruised up, enters and embraces Liz on the ground.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)
Every rock has a soft spot, like my son...

Liz places the Petoskey necklace down (now called the "Heirloom").

Shelby helps the grieving Liz exit.

[The real-life Andy Van Otteren's Memorial Poem written by his twin sister Sara may be included here, spoken or projected.]

END OF PROLOGUE

23. “WATER TO MY SOUL”

The Van Otterloos and Amanda walk on the bridge, leaving the Residents behind.

LIZZIE
WHEN?

CHERRY
WHEN?

PERRY
WHEN?

SHELBY
WHEN?

LIZZIE, AUNTIES, AMANDA
WHEN WILL I EVER LET GO?

Michilimackinac and the Mackinac Ghosts appear in the mist.

MACKINAC GHOSTS
WHEN YOU OPEN YOUR EYES AND SEE THE PAIN SHOW...

AMANDA
WHERE?

CHERRY
WHERE?

MACKINAC GHOSTS
WHERE?

PERRY
WHERE?

SHELBY
WHERE?

MACKINAC GHOSTS
WHERE?

LIZZIE, AUNTIES, AMANDA
WHERE DO ALL MY TEARS FLOW?

MACKINAC GHOSTS (CONT’D)
FLOW?

The Ghosts step aside to reveal Petey in all his glory.

MACKINAC GHOSTS (CONT’D)
WELL YOU JUST HAVE TO ASK THIS POOR SOUL...

LIZZIE
MY POOR SOUL...

PETEY
NOW A HAPPY SOUL...

LIZZIE & PETEY
YOU ARE WATER TO MY SOUL...

LIZZIE
WHERE YOU GO.

PETEY
I'LL FLOW!

AUNTIES & MACKINAC GHOSTS
NO MATTER WHERE I GO I WILL FLOW...

LIZZIE
UPSTREAM.

PETEY
DOWNSTREAM.

MACKINAC GHOSTS
YOU ARE WATER TO MY SOUL...

Liz and Petey kiss.

LIZZIE & PETEY
YOU ARE WATER TO MY SOUL...
MY SOUL...
YOU ARE MY SOUL!

Petey hugs Cherry and Perry. He and Shelby lock eyes. She lovingly slaps him before hugging him. They all share a final dance before he hands his broken Heirloom to Liz.

Liz joins Petoskey and Shelby joins Lulu.

Liz, Petoskey, Shelby, and Lulu wave as Petey vanishes with the other Ghosts once more into the foggy bridge.

Liz puts the Heirloom on Petoskey.

Amanda tosses her phone off the bridge. Conor's shadow appears in the mist. Amanda runs to him, disappearing in the fog.

The Van Otterloos continue on. They finally cross the bridge.

End of "WATER TO MY SOUL"

END OF ACT III

EPILOGUE

SCENE 1

EXT. ELK LAKE HOUSE - JANUARY 2037 - DAY

23A. "LIFE IS COMPLETE - REPRISE 2"

The Van Otterloos prepare themselves for the Michigan Bicentennial Parade.

LIZZIE
(Narrating)
Raise your hands if you've ever lost a loved one to suicide.

The Company hugs Audience Members who raise their hands.

LIZZIE (CONT'D)
We can cross the bridge. Year after year, moment after moment, we can still harbor good days.

VAN OTTERLOOS
You can cross the bridge!

